

last thing I had.

I was very insecure. I was bullied early on. I used to take medication, so my teeth were really yellow, and I would get bullied for that. At that time, all I felt was that I was good at just a couple of things — drawing and running. Going to school, I didn't find what I was good at straight away. It was just constantly being in spaces where I wasn't confident.

Now, you can say that I have this air of confidence about me, and it's only because I've been able to find what I'm good at and excel in that space. A lot of my mental health journey has been about trying to develop that. A lot of the time, when I talk to kids and people, I tell them that sometimes you just have to go through a really rough time to get to that final destination of what you're supposed to be.

You've spoken a lot about your challenges with mental health, and it's hard to think of a sport where it would be harder to face these challenges than the sprints.

I mean, it's such a crazy sport. There are fractions of a second that decide everything. Sometimes everything is decided before you even get on the track. The way I keep things level around me is by having a very close circle. The people in my circle know me, and I trust that they know me. So, if I'm behaving erratically, I trust them to call me out and say, 'Hey, you need to fix this behaviour.' And I'm like, 'OK, if I'm hearing it from you, that must mean it's true.' At the same time, if I'm looking for a safe space, they are that safe space.

It's thanks to them that I know my worth and value. I know who I am, and I don't look for validation elsewhere.

How much of what we see of you on social media or TV is a dialled-up-to-10 version of you?

It maybe a dialled-up-to-12 version of me. When I'm in my safe space, it's a pretty heavy dial-down. Some people are shocked at how relaxed I can be, especially in my own home. I'm pretty quiet there. I might be playing video games. I might be laughing

with friends. I don't have to be a 10 there.

At practice, though, I'm very driven. I might not even talk a lot because I'm hyper-focused on getting everything out of practice to make it better. Then, when we get to the races, I get to be the showman. I get to let out that personality, that excitement I've been building up.

But that's the misconception people sometimes have about me. The funniest one is when people expect me to be the same in my private life as I am on the track. That exuberance is very specifically for the sport setting. I might still carry my confidence outside it, but it's not over the top because that's no longer what's required of me.

People will come and meet me for the first time with the energy they see when I'm on the track. They'll go — 'Oh my gosh, it's Noah Lyles!' They'll be screaming at the top of their lungs and trying to hug me, and I'm thinking, 'Woah! You're a stranger to me. I don't even know you. You need to take a step back!'

They're wondering where all that energy has gone, but that's just for track meets. It's not for the public. I want everyone to use their inside voice then. If you come and meet me for the first time, I want you to introduce yourself with your name.

Do you feel some of that is almost like a character you have to play at times, or is it just a different part of you that comes out?

It's not that I'm playing a character; it's a different part of me. People asked me this when I was younger, and I've always been clear that it's all me, just dialled up to a higher level in those settings.

What's something you realised this year that others might not consider an accomplishment but which means a lot to you?

Something that means a lot to me has been watching the growth of the 200m as a competition. It's made me very emotional. When I first came into the sport, Bolt had just left. [Justin] Gatlin was on his way out. Yohan [Blake] was up and down. We

had this drought in the 200m, which was my favourite event. I had come in watching these runners, so, when I came into the sport, I wanted to make the event great. I didn't feel it was at the level I wanted to see.

So for the next five years, it was part of my mission to run fast and force everyone else to catch up. For a while, it didn't look like anybody was going to. Then I started to see the times and averages drop. All of a sudden, we're hearing that 2025 saw the fastest National Championship time in the 200m ever. We've had the fastest semifinal time at a World Championship. We've also had the fastest final we've ever seen in the Olympics. That has been very enjoyable to watch.

When I was young, the mentality was that you were there to win everything. Then you start having competitors, and you see new people coming in. I'm now at the age where the new athletes coming through watched me and are now fans. They ask for advice, and I'm almost put into a role-model position in the middle of my career. That's something I really enjoy because I want to see everyone run their best.

Track and field has this perception of being a very individualistic sport where no one really cares what the others are doing. You seem to really care about the sport.

This sport is my passion. It's my love. I was born into it. My parents were runners. My aunts, uncles and godparents were runners, Olympians or Olympic coaches. I was born into the track and field world. It's what I love, and I want to see it at its very best.

People drop this word a lot, and you are just 28, but are you already thinking about your legacy?

I've thought about that since I first turned professional, and probably even before that. I don't think my legacy is going to stop at any point just on the track. Everyone thinks they are eventually going to retire from the sport, but I don't think I'm